the country were inspired to stand against the established, inefficient and corrupt political parties. A host of independents, including well-known names such as noted danseuse Mallika Sarabhai in Ahmedabad and aviation entrepreneur Captain Gopinath in Bengaluru, joined the fray.

My campaign received support from young people across the country, who felt it symbolized their aspirations for a clean, efficient, corruption-free India, where they could flourish in an environment of equal opportunity. This theme was taken up subsequently by Anna Hazare and the India Against Corruption movement, which finally culminated in the formation of the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) led by Arvind Kejriwal.

South Mumbai is the financial capital of India, and in 2009, it contributed 39 per cent of India's direct taxes. However, other than for the ultra-rich, it is a hard place to live in and work. Real estate is amongst the most expensive in the world, commuting to work by the jam-packed suburban rail system can be life-threatening, and there aren't enough schools, colleges, and medical and sport facilities. Open spaces are few and far between, and the civic infrastructure has crumbled.

During my campaign, I walked through each and every street, slum and chawl in my constituency – meeting the brave people who struggled every day, against great odds, in this erstwhile city of gold. The perceived threat of my candidacy was so great that even the then Prime Minister of India came to Mumbai, to appeal to voters not to vote for independents like me![1] And though I lost the election, I learnt a lot about the politics of our country.

Post the 2009 elections, I resumed my job as the Chairperson and CEO of the bank. During the next five years, I spent all my spare time in learning the dynamics of my constituency and searching for solutions that would help improve both the quality of life and governance in south Mumbai. My study led to me to conclude that the root cause for poor conditions of life there was the shortage of land. I